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ACTION NEA-07

INFO OCT-01 EUR-12 ISO-00 OES-09 NASA-02 NSF-02 DOE-15

SOE-02 CIAE-00 PM-05 H-02 INR-10 L-03 NSAE-00

NSC-05 PA-02 SP-02 SS-15 NAS-01 /095 W

-----102479 290900Z /11

R 290606Z JAN 79

FM AMEMBASSY KUWAIT

TO SECSTATE WASHDC 2864

INFO AMEMBASSY ABU DHABI

AMEMBASSY DOHA

AMEMBASSY LONDON

AMEMBASSY MANAMA

AMEMBASSY MUSCAT

SECDEF WASHDC

USCINCEUR

USICA WASHDC

UNCLAS KUWAIT 0486

CINCEUR ALSO FOR POLAD

E.O. 12065: N/A

TAGS: MPOL, PINS, MASS, SOPN, TGEN, KU

SUBJECT: "UFO" SIGHTINGS CAUSE SECURITY CONCERN IN KUWAIT

1. A SERIES OF "UFO" SIGHTINGS ON NOVEMBER 9 CAUSED THE GOK TO APPOINT AN INVESTIGATORY COMMITTEE OF EXPERTS FROM THE KUWAIT INSTITUTE FOR SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH (KISR). THE COMMITTEE'S REPORT WHICH WAS RELEASED JANUARY 20 DESCRIBED EIGHT SIGHTINGS FROM NOVEMBER TO DECEMBER 14. A NUMBER OF THE EARLY SIGHTINGS TOOK PLACE NEAR A KUWAIT OIL COMPANY GATHERING CENTER NORTH OF KUWAIT CITY. RELEASE OF THE COMMITTEE'S REPORT WAS SOMETHING OF A MEDIA EVENT AS IT COINCIDED WITH JAN 21 FRONT PAGE STORIES OF YET ANOTHER "UFO" SIGHTING OVER KUWAIT CITY, WHICH INCLUDED PHOTOGRAPHS IN LOCAL NEWSPAPERS.

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2. THE KISR COMMITTEE REJECTED THE NOTION THAT THE "UFO'S" WERE ESPIONAGE DEVICES BUT REMAINED EQUIVOCAL ABOUT WHETHER THEY WERE OF EXTRATERRESTRIAL ORIGIN. THE KISR COMMITTEE REPRESENTATIVE, RATIB ABU ID, TOLD EMBOFF THAT THE SCIENTISTS DID NOT KNOW ENOUGH ABOUT THE PHENOMENA TO SAY WITH CERTAINTY THAT THEY WEREN'T

"SPACESHIPS." THE REPORT WENT

ON TO RECOMMEND THAT THE GOVERNMENT TAKE ALL POSSIBLE MEASURES TO PROTECT KUWAIT'S AIR SPACE AND TERRITORY AS WELL AS THE COUNTRY'S OIL RESOURCES.

3. SOME LOCAL WAGS HAVE MADE LIGHT OF THE FIRST UFO SIGHTINGS WHICH CAME NEAR THE END OF THE LONG AND TRADITIONALLY EXUBERANT HOLIDAY CELEBRATIONS OF ID-ALADHA. HOWEVER WE HAVE LEARNED RECENTLY OF AN EVENT COINCIDENT WITH ONE OF THE UFO SIGHTINGS WHICH HAS CONFOUNDED SOME OF OUR MOST LEVEL-HEADED KUWAITI FRIENDS, AND MAY HAVE BEEN WHAT PERSUADED THE GOK TO MAKE A SERIOUS INVESTIGATION OF THE MATTER. A SENIOR KUWAIT OIL COMPANY (KOC) OFFICIAL TOLD US THE "UFO" WHICH FIRST APPEARED OVER THE NORTHERN OIL FIELDS SEEMINGLY DID STRANGE THINGS TO KOC'S AUTOMATIC PUMPING EQUIPMENT.

THIS EQUIPMENT IS DESIGNED TO SHUT ITSELF DOWN WHEN THERE IS SOME FAILURE WHICH MAY SERIOUSLY DAMAGE THE PETROLEUM GATHERING AND TRANSMISSION SYSTEM AND IT CAN ONLY BE RESTARTED MANUALLY. AT THE TIME OF THE "UFO'S" APPEARANCE THE PUMPING SYSTEM AUTOMATICALLY SHUT ITSELF DOWN AND WHEN THE "UFO" VANISHED THE SYSTEM STARTED ITSELF UP AGAIN. THIS EVENT WAS NOT ADDRESSED BY THE KISR COMMITTEE REPORT.

4. EVEN THOSE WHO ARE NOT INCLINED TO BELIEVE IN

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VISITORS FROM OUTER SPACE DO TEND TO THINK SOMETHING STRANGE HAS BEEN GOING ON IN KUWAITI AIRSPACE. THERE HAS BEEN SPECULATION, FOR EXAMPLE, ABOUT HELICOPTERS OR HOVERCRAFT BRINGING REFUGEES OR MONEY OUT OF BELEAGUERED IRAN. AT THE LEAST, THE PHENOMENA HAVE STIMULATED A NEW DEGREE OF INTEREST AMONG TOP KUWAITI OFFICIALS IN THE COUNTRY'S AIR DEFENSE SYSTEM, WHICH DID NOT REACT IN ANY WAY TO THE "EVENTS" IN THE KOC NORTH FIELD BECAUSE IT WAS CLOSED DOWN FOR THE NIGHT (SEPTEL).

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